

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

PRAYING FOR THE MUSLIM VOTE? Mamata Banerjee at the Kolkata Municipal Corporation's Dawat-e-Iftar party, Apr. 12

WEST BENGAL

DIDI'S GIFTS FOR MINORITIES

of concern for the TMC, since the Muslim vote share in its kitty tends to rise and fall in proportion to the BJP's perceived strength. As per CSDS Lokniti post-poll surveys, TMC got 51 per cent of the state's Muslim votes in the 2016 assembly polls, when the BJP was not a factor. However, facing a beefed up and aggressive BJP raising the Hindutva pitch in the 2019 LS polls and in 2021, TMC got 70 per cent and 75 per cent of Muslim votes, respectively.

For Muslim voters, it's a simple enough choice. "It has become easier for us to choose. Minorities go for the party which can ensure security. Mamata has been able to guarantee this. Joblessness, inflation and corruption become non-issues," says Syed Noor-ur-Rahman Barkati, the former Shahi Imam of the Tipu Sultan Masjid in Kolkata.

The state budgetary allocations for minority affairs and madrasa departments in 2023-24 speak volumes too. For the welfare of its 35 million minority population, mostly Muslims, the budget has allocated Rs 5,004.05 crore; the Centre's allocation for the same for the entire country this year is Rs 3,097.60 crore.

BENGAL ALLOCATED Rs 5,004 CRORE FOR MINORITY WELFARE THIS YEAR. THE CENTRAL BUDGET HAS EARMARKED Rs 3,097 CRORE

CPI(M) state secretary Mohammed Salim feels such allocations are just for show. "Funds of one department are used to meet the expenses of another...there are examples of assets, like polytechnics and ITI colleges, created with the minority affairs department budget being handed over to NGOs and private players," he says.

That said, this year's budget also earmarks Rs 1,000 crore for scholarships to 4.5 million students, since education and government jobs continue to be the principal demands of the minorities. The 'Aikyashree' scholarship for minority students was started in 2019. "The government is giving education loans of Rs 30 lakh for professional courses," says Golam Rabbani, a former minority affairs minister. However, many applicants say they haven't been able to access the loans. Around 45 per cent applications to the Vivekananda merit-cum-means scholarships for disadvantaged students were also rejected, say sources.

It is in the light of Mamata's steadfast Muslim outreach that her consternation over the loss in the Sagardighi bypoll in Murshidabad district, which has 61 per cent Muslim population, should be seen. Fearing that Muslim votes were swinging towards the Congress and Left parties—a Congress candidate backed by the Left won—Mamata took swift action: Rabbani was removed as minister, and she herself assumed charge. Currently, Mamata is trying to use a recent central notification for elimination of illegal Aadhaar cards in swathes of North and South 24 Parganas districts bordering Bangladesh to stoke NRC and CAA fears. "Why are they selective about places where updating and elimination will take place? Is it to target a particular community?" she asked. The counter question to that couls well be: will it help her retain the crucial vote bank? ■